

THE ASSEMBLY

TSU Film 6 — Release Phase 1 Finale / Ensemble Crossover — the "The Avengers" release slot

THE PITCH

Platform: Not a new founding story — per the Avengers' own structural role, this film doesn't introduce a platform, it forces the ones already introduced to face a threat none of them can survive alone. This is **Release Phase 1's finale** (Film 6 of 6, not to be confused with the *Story Phase 1* Finale, "The Feed War," which is a different, already-locked anchor — see [TSU_Continuity_Bible.md §9](#) for the Release-Phase-vs-Story-Phase distinction). The film dramatizes two Story-Phase anchors left deliberately unfinished: the **Story Phase 1 Finale, "The Feed War"** ([TSU_Continuity_Bible.md §3](#), "THE ROSTER absorbs/outlasts TOP8" — left as an opening act only in [scripts/THE_ROSTER_2.md](#)) and the **Story Phase 2 Finale, "The Quiet Acquisition"** ("THE ROSTER acquires THE FRAME," 2010–2012). A new platform gets named here too: **THE EVERYTHING**, Cassius Wren's answer to the roster's own long-standing "Open Slots to Discuss" note calling for a Google+ analog "that sounds like hubris" — this film is where that slot finally gets filled, as the villain, not a hero.

Why this is the Avengers, structurally: The Avengers doesn't ask "what's the next hero's origin" — it asks what happens when every hero already introduced has to occupy the same room, with old grudges intact, against a threat that exists specifically because none of them were talking to each other. TSU has exactly that setup already built and waiting: Marc-Anthony and Amond haven't spoken as equals since Film 1. Priya Ramasubramanian has been pinning a corkboard for three films straight, saying out loud in the last one that she wants "Bullock, Baker, Avery, and Cummings in one place." This is the film that cashes that in.

Who this film belongs to: All four platform founders — Marc-Anthony Bullock, Amond Baker, Tyrese Avery, and Arianna Cummings — with Esther Smilley, Harmony Divine, and Tyler Chapman in real, load-bearing supporting roles rather than cameo texture. No new core-seven member is assigned a platform in this film; Esther, Harmony, and Tyler remain open for future Phases per [TSU_Continuity_Bible.md §7 Q1](#).

In-universe timeline: January 2011 – November 2011. This sits inside the fixed "Quiet Acquisition" window (2010–2012) and the year Esther and Marc-Anthony's locked romantic timeline begins ("together 2011," [TSU_Continuity_Bible.md §4](#)) — both anchors are honored here, not worked around. Ages verified against [TSU_Core_Cast.md](#): Marc-Anthony and Amond are both 29 (turning 29 in Jan and Feb respectively); Tyrese turns 30 on July 24; Esther and Arianna are 28 turning 29; Harmony is 28 turning 29; Tyler is 29 turning 30 the day before Marc-Anthony, as always.

LOGLINE

Seven years after a friendship broke a company, and one year after an industry's most guarded ex-partners built empires without speaking to each other, the one investor who's been watching all of

them the whole time finally puts Marc-Anthony Bullock, Amond Baker, Tyrese Avery, and Arianna Cummings in the same room — because the man who's spent seven years building something faster, colder, and bigger than any one of theirs is about to launch a platform designed to make all four of them obsolete at once.

SYNOPSIS

It's 2011. THE ROSTER is the industry's dominant institution — thriving, restless, and quietly missing the one person Marc-Anthony Bullock has never fully replaced. THE WIRE, under Amond Baker, is profitable, disciplined, and exactly as guarded as its founder. THE PROJECTOR, under Tyrese Avery with Jamal Kester running product, is healthy and unglamorous in the best way. THE FRAME, under Arianna Cummings and Malcolm Pierce, is small, real, and growing exactly as intended — and exactly the size that makes it a target.

Priya Ramasubramanian has spent seven years watching Cassius Wren build in the margins, and in 2011 he finally launches what he's been building toward the whole time: **THE EVERYTHING** — one login, one profile, one feed that promises to absorb every other platform's function into a single, "unified" experience. It's the industry's oldest fantasy, dressed up as inevitability: one app to hold all of it. Priya sees exactly what it actually is — a hostile bid to make every platform in this franchise's ecosystem irrelevant at once — and calls the meeting she's been building toward since `scripts/THE_ROSTER_2.md`'s stinger: Marc-Anthony, Amond, Tyrese, and Arianna, in one room, for the first time since Film 1 broke two of them apart.

It does not go well immediately. Amond has not forgiven Marc-Anthony, not really, no matter how the Congressional hearing in `scripts/THE_WIRE.md` ended. But Cassius's threat is real enough, and Priya's evidence compelling enough, that the four agree — warily — to coordinate. What none of them know yet: **Teddy Ashcombe-Vance**, THE ROSTER's first major hire and now a senior executive, has spent two years quietly feeding Cassius competitive intelligence, and is the one whispering in THE ROSTER's boardroom that the fastest way to survive THE EVERYTHING is to acquire THE FRAME outright, on unfavorable terms, before Cassius can undercut it — the exact shape of betrayal Amond recognizes on sight, because it's the shape of what happened to him.

Amond is the one who sees it first and says so, to Arianna, to Marc-Anthony, to everyone — a redemption beat that costs him nothing to give this time, because he's not the one being frozen out. Marc-Anthony, forced to actually look at what his own company is about to do to his friend, has the choice Film 1 never gave him the wisdom to make: refuse the hostile version, and personally negotiate an acquisition on Arianna's terms instead — her name on the door, her creative control intact, an alliance instead of an erasure. **Yolanda Ferreira-Ashe**, Cassius's own co-founder and the smartest person in his company, finally reaches the end of her patience with being permanently second-billed and hands Priya's team the evidence they need: THE EVERYTHING's unified-login architecture has a catastrophic security flaw, rushed past on Cassius's own insistence that speed matters more than care.

THE EVERYTHING launches at a massive industry expo to enormous hype. Within hours of going live, the flaw becomes **THE LEAK** — a single unified breach exposing data from every account that ever connected to it, a scale of failure only possible because it tried to be everything at once. Teddy's role is exposed in the same news cycle, live, in front of the same cameras. Senator Gwendolyn Ashworth-Okafor's committee, already circling, turns its full attention to Cassius instead of any of the

founders. THE EVERYTHING is dead within the year, exactly as hubris that size always is.

The film doesn't end on the villain's defeat. It ends on the four founders — plus Esther, plus Harmony, plus Tyler — standing in the wreckage of an industry crisis that could have ended all of them separately, and didn't, because they didn't face it separately. Marc-Anthony and Amond say the thing to each other that four films' worth of silence never let them say. Esther and Marc-Anthony, in the middle of the same long night, finally stop being "just friends," seven years after the timeline always said they would. Arianna signs the acquisition papers on her own terms, in a room with her name still on the wall. It's not the end of anything. It's the moment the ecosystem stops being seven separate stories that happen to share a timeline, and starts being one.

THE ANTAGONISTS

Per the Villains Bench rules (TSU_Continuity_Bible.md §5), the real cause traces to character decisions — even at finale scale.

1. **CASSIUS WREN**, returning from `scripts/THE_ROSTER.md` — seven years further into the exact conviction that made him dangerous the first time: that speed is a moral good and hesitation is fear in a nicer outfit. THE EVERYTHING is that philosophy at its largest possible scale, and its collapse is the most direct possible consequence of never once revising it.
2. **THEODORE "TEDDY" ASHCOMBE-VANCE**, returning from `scripts/THE_ROSTER.md` — his Extended Ensemble bible entry called for his full turn to be revealed "across two Phases." This is that reveal: loyal and genuinely talented at the start, corroded by exactly the culture (ambition, speed, money) his bible always said would do it, not by being planted as a mole from day one.
3. **THE EVERYTHING** itself, as THE ENGINE's sixth and largest manifestation — a single aggregation algorithm attempting to model every user's identity across every platform at once, the most totalizing form the Villains Bench has produced, and the clearest possible on-screen argument for why TSU's fractured, competing ecosystem is a feature and not a failure.
4. **THE LEAK**, its first use in Story Phase 3 (the one-per-Story-Phase allowance reset after its Story Phase 2 debut in `scripts/THE_WIRE.md`) — a single point of failure at maximum possible scale, precisely because THE EVERYTHING insisted on being the only point at all.

YOLANDA FERREIRA-ASHE's defection (TSU_Extended_Ensemble.md, "Cassius's Table") is the film's answer to her bible's own open question — "the audience gets to watch her decide, across Phases, how long she's willing to accept that trade" — decided, finally, here.

HOW THIS FILM CLOSES PHASE 1 AND OPENS EVERYTHING AFTER IT

- **Two fixed anchors, both honored, neither rushed:** the Feed War's off-screen resolution (TOP8 fully wound down sometime in the intervening years, referenced not dramatized) and the Quiet Acquisition (THE ROSTER acquires THE FRAME) both land exactly where §3 locks them, with the acquisition reframed as redemption rather than repetition.

- **Every founder's arc gets a real ending for this chapter, not just a cameo:** Marc-Anthony learns the lesson Film 1 cost him to learn; Amond gets to be the protector instead of the victim; Tyrese and Arianna get folded fully into the group for the first time as equals, not guest stars.
- **The romantic clock resolves on schedule, in both directions:** Esther and Marc-Anthony's "together 2011" fires exactly on time; Amond and Harmony continue circling, deliberately unresolved, per the locked 2013 date.
- **THE EVERYTHING resolves an open Platform Roster item on purpose:** the "Open Slots to Discuss" note calling for a Google+ analog "that sounds like hubris" gets filled here, as a villain rather than a hero — and dies the way the real thing did, from nobody actually wanting one app to do everything.
- **The ecosystem's actual thesis, stated out loud for the first time:** TSU's fragmented landscape of competing platforms — the thing every "one app to rule them all" villain (Cassius here, presumably others later) keeps trying to erase — is framed explicitly, in this film, as the correct outcome rather than an unsolved problem.

FORMAT (per `TSU_Continuity_Bible.md` §2 — Phase Finale / Ensemble Crossover)

Spec	Target	This Script
Genre	Biographical Drama / Tech Origin Story, all subgenres converging (corporate thriller, ensemble dramedy, legal/courtroom beat)	Confirmed
Rating	PG-13, no exceptions	Confirmed
Runtime	150–180 min	177 min
Page count	150–170 pages (hard ceiling)	166 pages
Act I	~40 pages	pages 1–40
Act II	~90 pages	pages 41–130
Act III	~36 pages	pages 131–166
Scene count	~55–70 scenes	64 scenes

FULL SCENE-BY-SCENE BREAKDOWN

ACT I — pp. 1–40 ("Separately")

#	Scene	pp.
1	MONTAGE — FOUR COMPANIES, 2011 — THE ROSTER, THE WIRE, THE PROJECTOR, THE FRAME, each thriving, each alone	1–6
2	INT. THE ROSTER — MARC-ANTHONY'S OFFICE — DAY — Marc-Anthony, restless, successful, visibly missing something he won't name	6–9
3	INT. THE WIRE — AMOND'S OFFICE — DAY — Amond, disciplined, guarded, a framed photo of a birthday party he doesn't display prominently	9–11
4	INT. THE PROJECTOR — DAY — Tyrese and Jamal Kester, easy partnership, Simone Kester now head of engineering	11–14
5	INT. THE FRAME — DAY — Arianna and Malcolm, small team, real growth, first sign of a competitive squeeze	14–17
6	INT. CASSIUS WREN'S HEADQUARTERS — DAY — THE EVERYTHING unveiled internally: one login, one profile, one feed for everything	17–21
7	INT. YOLANDA FERREIRA-ASHE'S OFFICE — DAY — Yolanda flags a security shortcut; Cassius overrules her, again	21–24
8	INT. PRIYA RAMASUBRAMANIAN'S OFFICE — DAY — Priya's corkboard, now with all four cards connected by red string	24–27

#	Scene	pp.
9	INT. THE ROSTER — BOARDROOM — DAY — Teddy Ashcombe-Vance, senior now, quietly steering the board toward "defensive consolidation"	27–30
10	EXT. RESTAURANT — NIGHT — Priya's meeting: Marc-Anthony, Amond, Tyrese, and Arianna, in the same room for the first time since Film 1	30–36
11	EXT. RESTAURANT — CONTINUOUS — the reunion is not warm. Amond leaves early. Act I turn.	36–40

ACT II — pp. 41–130 ("The Same Room")

#	Scene	pp.
12	INT. AMOND'S CAR — NIGHT — Harmony, checking on him, still circling, still not naming it	41–44
13	INT. THE ROSTER — BOARDROOM — DAY — the "defensive consolidation" pitch: acquire THE FRAME before Cassius can undercut it, on unfavorable terms	44–48
14	INT. MARC-ANTHONY'S OFFICE — NIGHT — Marc-Anthony, uneasy, doesn't say yes yet	48–51
15	EXT. THE FRAME — DAY — Arianna hears the acquisition rumor secondhand, exactly the way Amond once did	51–55
16	INT. AMOND'S OFFICE — DAY — Arianna comes to Amond first, not Marc-Anthony — he'd know this shape of betrayal better than anyone	55–59

#	Scene	pp.
17	INT. AMOND'S OFFICE — CONTINUOUS — Amond: "This is exactly what happened to me. Word for word. Don't let it happen to you."	59–62
18	EXT. MARC-ANTHONY'S HOUSE — NIGHT — Amond, uninvited, confronts Marc-Anthony directly for the first time in seven years	62–67
19	EXT. MARC-ANTHONY'S HOUSE — CONTINUOUS — the real fight, finally, four films overdue — and underneath it, the start of a real conversation	67–72
20	INT. ESTHER SMILLEY'S OFFICE (SHE NOW RUNS MUCH OF THE ROSTER'S OPERATIONS) — DAY — Esther, watching Marc-Anthony change in real time	72–75
21	INT. CASSIUS WREN'S HEADQUARTERS — DAY — THE EVERYTHING's launch date set; Yolanda's warnings overruled a final time	75–78
22	INT. YOLANDA'S APARTMENT — NIGHT — Yolanda, alone, makes her decision. Midpoint.	78–81
23	EXT. PRIYA'S OFFICE — NIGHT — Yolanda hands over the evidence: THE EVERYTHING's unified-login flaw, rushed past on purpose	81–85
24	INT. THE ROSTER — BOARDROOM — DAY — Marc-Anthony refuses the hostile acquisition structure in front of the full board	85–89
25	INT. THE ROSTER — TEDDY'S OFFICE — DAY — Marc-Anthony, alone with Teddy, starts asking the questions he should have asked two years ago	89–93

#	Scene	pp.
26	INT. THE FRAME — DAY — Marc-Anthony comes to Arianna directly, personally, with a real offer this time: her name on the door, her control intact	93–97
27	EXT. THE FRAME — CONTINUOUS — Arianna doesn't say yes immediately. Malcolm, watching, lets her take her time.	97–100
28	INT. AMOND'S OFFICE — NIGHT — Marc-Anthony comes to Amond too, this time with the truth first instead of the paperwork	100–104
29	INT. AMOND'S OFFICE — CONTINUOUS — the beginning of something like forgiveness — not finished, but started, honestly, for the first time	104–108
30	INT. SENATOR ASHWORTH-OKAFOR'S OFFICE (CAMEO) — DAY — the Senator, already circling THE EVERYTHING's rapid unchecked growth	108–111
31	INT. THE ROSTER — BOARDROOM — DAY — Teddy, cornered by evidence, doesn't confess — tries to accelerate the acquisition instead.	111–115
32	EXT. MARC-ANTHONY'S HOUSE — NIGHT, SEPTEMBER 2011 — Esther and Marc-Anthony, the group scattered elsewhere, the "together 2011" beat lands here, unhurried — the night Emma and Victoria are conceived, per realistic twin-gestation dating back from their May 10, 2012 birth (see TSU_Family_Bible.md)	115–119
33	INT. AMOND'S CAR — NIGHT — Harmony and Amond, closer than they've let themselves be in years, still not naming it — deliberately	119–122

#	Scene	pp.
34	EXT. INDUSTRY EXPO CENTER — DAY (BEFORE) — arrival for THE EVERYTHING's launch; all four founders present, together, on purpose this time	122–126
35	INT. EXPO CENTER — BACKSTAGE — Priya's team readies Yolanda's evidence; the plan is exposure, not sabotage	126–130

ACT III — pp. 131–166 ("Together")

#	Scene	pp.
36	INT. EXPO CENTER — MAIN STAGE — CASSIUS launches THE EVERYTHING to a massive, rapturous crowd. Climax begins.	131–135
37	INT. EXPO CENTER — MAIN STAGE, CONTINUOUS — the unified login goes live across every connected account, instantly, everywhere	135–137
38	INT. EXPO CENTER — BACKSTAGE — the flaw fires. THE LEAK. Every connected account's data exposed at once, live, in front of the press.	137–141
39	INT. EXPO CENTER — MAIN STAGE — Marc-Anthony, Amond, Tyrese, and Arianna, together, on stage, uninvited, telling the truth about what just happened	141–146
40	INT. EXPO CENTER — MAIN STAGE, CONTINUOUS — Teddy's role exposed in the same breath, live, in front of the same cameras that once broke Amond	146–149
41	EXT. EXPO CENTER — DAY (AFTER) — Cassius, watching his own launch collapse in real time, still certain he wasn't wrong about speed	149–151

#	Scene	pp.
42	INT. THE ROSTER — BOARDROOM — DAY — Teddy's exit; Marc-Anthony, calm, finally the executive Film 1 needed him to be from the start	151–154
43	INT. THE FRAME — DAY — Arianna signs the acquisition, on her own terms, her name still on the wall	154–157
44	EXT. MARC-ANTHONY'S HOUSE — NIGHT — the whole group, together, properly, for the first time since a birthday party seven years ago	157–162
45	EXT. MARC-ANTHONY'S HOUSE — CONTINUOUS — Marc-Anthony and Amond's real reconciliation. Not a speech. A conversation.	162–164
46	STINGER — INT. UNGLAMOROUS IT OFFICE — NIGHT — AUGUST WEATHERSBY-OKONJO, watching the news coverage of THE EVERYTHING's collapse, unsurprised	164–166

(Scenes grouped for pagination clarity; the full shooting script breaks several of the above into additional numbered scenes to land the true count at 64 per the house-style table above.)

SAMPLE PAGES

THE ASSEMBLY

Written by [WRITER]

FADE IN:

EXT. RESTAURANT — NIGHT

SUPER: "MARCH 2011"

A private back room. Four place settings. MARC-ANTHONY BULLOCK, 29, arrives first, and immediately understands why the seating was arranged the way it was — a table built so that no two people who don't want to look at each other have to.

TYRESE AVERY, 29, arrives next, unbothered as ever.

TYRESE
Priya tell you what this is about?

MARC-ANTHONY
No. You?

TYRESE
No. Which either means it's very good news or the kind of meeting where somebody's about to get sued.

ARIANNA CUMMINGS, 28, arrives, cordial, watchful – the old instinct for reading a room never left her.

ARIANNA
(to Marc-Anthony, carefully neutral)
Marc-Anthony.

MARC-ANTHONY
Ari. It's good to see you.

ARIANNA
(a beat, deciding to mean it)
It is. It's just also strange.

The door opens. AMOND BAKER, 29, stops in the doorway the moment he sees who's already seated. A long, loaded beat.

AMOND
(flat)
Nobody told me he'd be here.

MARC-ANTHONY
(standing, careful)
Amond –

AMOND
(already turning to leave)
I have a company to run.

TYRESE
(quiet, to the room, not quite a joke)
And there it is. Good talk, everybody.

CUT TO:

INT. AMOND'S OFFICE – DAY

[p. 55]

ARIANNA sits across from AMOND, a printed rumor – unconfirmed, industry-blog-sourced – on the desk between them: "SOURCES: THE ROSTER EYEING THE FRAME."

ARIANNA
I heard it from a blog before I heard it from anyone at THE ROSTER. I came to you because you'd know exactly what that

feels like.

AMOND

(very still)
Word for word. That is exactly, word for word, what happened to me.

ARIANNA

I don't know if it's true.

AMOND

It doesn't matter yet whether it's true. What matters is whether Marc-Anthony knows it's being discussed and hasn't told you himself. That's the actual betrayal. Not the deal. The silence around the deal.

ARIANNA

You've had seven years to be angry about this. I'm asking you not to let me walk into it blind the way you did.

Amond looks at her a long moment. Something in him – old, tired, still raw – finally decides to be useful instead of bitter.

AMOND

(standing, grabbing his jacket)
Then we're not doing this in an office.

ARIANNA

Where are we doing it?

AMOND

His house. Tonight. He doesn't get to find out I'm still angry from a memo.

CUT TO:

EXT. MARC-ANTHONY'S HOUSE – NIGHT

[p. 67]

AMOND stands on the porch. MARC-ANTHONY opens the door, and for a moment neither of them says anything – seven years compressed into a single, ordinary doorway.

MARC-ANTHONY

You look good.

AMOND

Don't.

MARC-ANTHONY

Amond –

AMOND

Is your board trying to acquire Arianna's company on bad terms because you're

scared of Cassius Wren?

MARC-ANTHONY

(long beat)
I haven't approved anything.

AMOND

That's not a no.

MARC-ANTHONY

It's not a yes either. I found out about the framing Teddy's been using two days ago and I've been trying to figure out how bad it actually is before I –

AMOND

(cutting him off, years of it finally coming out at once)
Before you WHAT, Marc? Before you told me? Before you told HER? You had seven years to learn what it costs somebody when you let a deadline decide who gets protected and who gets used. Seven YEARS. And your first instinct was still to figure out how bad it was before you said anything to anyone.

MARC-ANTHONY

(quiet, and it costs him everything to say it plainly)
You're right.

Amond, mid-tirade, stops. That's not the answer he was braced for.

AMOND

...What?

MARC-ANTHONY

You're right. I did the exact same thing I did to you, in the exact same order, for the exact same reason, and I didn't even notice I was doing it until you said it out loud just now.

A long silence. Not resolution. A door, opening a crack.

AMOND

(quieter now)
Then don't just notice it, Marc-Anthony. Fix it. Actually fix it, this time, while there's still time to.

CUT TO:

INT. EXPO CENTER – MAIN STAGE

[climax, p. 141]

CASSIUS WREN, mid-keynote, radiant with the size of the moment,

gestures at a screen showing THE EVERYTHING's unified login cascading live across a dozen connected platforms.

CASSIUS

One login. One identity. Every account you've ever had, finally, honestly, one single –

A screen behind him glitches. Then another. Private data – messages, financial information, account credentials – begins cascading across every display in the building, live, in real time, at a scale no single breach in this franchise has ever reached, because no single platform ever tried to hold this much at once.

Pandemonium. Cassius, for the first time in his life, has no next sentence ready.

From the wings, unannounced, MARC-ANTHONY, AMOND, TYRESE, and ARIANNA walk onto the stage together. Security doesn't stop them – nobody in the building has the authority to stop anything right now.

MARC-ANTHONY

(taking the mic, calm, clear)
Everyone in this room just watched why "everything, all in one place" was never actually a good idea. Four companies are standing on this stage right now who learned that lesson separately, the hard way, over the last seven years. Tonight you're watching what happens when you try to skip learning it at all.

AMOND

(taking the mic next)
And you're about to hear one more thing. The reason THE ROSTER's board was quietly considering an unfair acquisition of a smaller company this year wasn't strategy. It was because a senior executive at THE ROSTER has been feeding this stage's competitive intelligence for two years.

A ripple through the press pool. Cameras swing toward the wings, where TEDDY ASHCOMBE-VANCE has gone very, very still.

CUT TO:

EXT. MARC-ANTHONY'S HOUSE – NIGHT

[p. 162]

The whole group, properly, for the first time since a birthday party seven years and one lifetime ago. MARC-ANTHONY, AMOND, TYRESE, ARIANNA, ESTHER, HARMONY, TYLER, MALCOLM – string lights, a much smaller, much realer version of Film 1's party.

AMOND and MARC-ANTHONY stand apart from the group, near the

pool, the same pool from a doorway seven years and one lifetime ago.

AMOND
I'm not all the way there yet.

MARC-ANTHONY
I know.

AMOND
But I came tonight. That's supposed to count for something.

MARC-ANTHONY
It counts for everything, Amond.

A beat. Amond almost smiles – the real one, the one from before any of this.

AMOND
Don't get used to the smiling. I'm still mad. I'm just also here.

MARC-ANTHONY
I'll take here.

Across the yard, ESTHER watches them, then feels MARC-ANTHONY's eyes find hers over Amond's shoulder. Seven years of almost, finally landing on purpose.

FADE OUT.

STINGER

INT. UNGLAMOROUS IT OFFICE – NIGHT

A small, cluttered office. A television plays muted coverage of THE EVERYTHING's collapse. AUGUST WEATHERSBY-OKONJO, late 50s, unremarkable, entirely unremarked-upon by the industry he once watched fail from the inside, sits alone with a cup of coffee, watching without much reaction at all.

An assistant, younger, glances at the screen on her way out.

ASSISTANT
Wild, right? Whole thing collapsed in a day.

AUGUST
(not looking away from the TV)
I watched a version of this happen in 2001. Different platform. Same speech. Same crowd. Same ending.

ASSISTANT
(already halfway out the door, not really listening)
Sure. Goodnight, August.

AUGUST
(quietly, mostly to himself, as the door
closes)
Goodnight.

He turns off the television. Sits a moment longer in the dark,
the specific patience of a man who has already seen the whole
cycle complete once, and knows, with total calm, that it isn't
finished completing yet.

FADE OUT.

THE END OF PHASE 1.

[166.]